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Carmen Lundy

Multi-talented Carmen Lundy is a celebrated vocalist, songwriter, arranger, visual artist, and film producer. Her socially conscious original work is expertly portrayed on her most recent release "Fade to Black."

Carmen was interviewed via Zoom on February 15, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very privileged to have Carmen Lundy with me this afternoon for me, and good morning to you.

CL: Good morning, Monk.

MR: I had planned out an introduction and then this morning I was reading Scott Yanow *Jazz Singers, the Ultimate Guide* which you are in. And so I'm going to read Scott's description. It said "Carmen Lundy's voice is deep, versatile and very appealing. She is a masterful yet subtle improviser, writes high quality music, some of which should become future standards, arranges for her band and puts on intriguing performances." And I might add she is a multi-instrumentalist, a mixed media artist, and an actress.

CL: Yes, and I just won my first film festival award.

MR: All right. And I should add, you are a joy to watch on stage. This morning I was watching the event from Madrid.

CL: Live at Madrid. Yeah.

MR: And your physical movements to the music are let's say highly appropriate. So can you remember a time when you were young when you, the first time that you thought, "I'm going to be a musician?"

CL: I can recall the first time I knew that it was going to be my life's — the goal, and that it was going to be my life's work but I didn't know necessarily that I was going to be a musician. I was already a musician when I decided that, that I was going to make it my profession. I was already a musician by then so I guess the decision to really pursue this was around the age of eleven or twelve, but I had already been playing piano for a good six, seven years prior to that.

MR: And accompanying yourself?

CL: Yes.

MR: So your mother was a member of an apostolic — sorry I didn't say it correctly.

CL: That's okay. People say apostolic and that's perfectly fine.

MR: Apostolic Christian church and was there a part of their doctrine that addressed popular music?

CL: Absolutely. Absolutely. When I mentioned a second ago that I won this award for best documentary film it was actually a film about my mother's Gospel group, the Apostolic Singers as we call it, of Miami. And that's kind of a branch of the Pentecostal teaching in Christianity, okay, the apostolic faith is sort of under this Pentecostal thing. And while we — you know my family, everyone in my family sings, plays an instrument, something. And my grandfather played violin and guitar. He was the one that started the Apostolic Singers. He and his brother built the little community that was part of where I grew up, Perrine, Florida, Richmond Heights, Florida. That's all kind of South of Coral Gables and Coconut Grove. So this area, I mean I was born in the mid-50s so this area was predominantly black, although we were very much a cosmopolitan and international city at the time, you know Miami Beach — some of my first gigs were on Miami Beach. This particular branch of Pentecostal faith frowns upon any connection whatsoever to making money as a musician, to actually earning money as a musician. It is, it's sort of a, there's a bit of a conflict, a bit of a — what is that word when you're kind of — contradictory — where if you have a gift, and you received this gift from God and you don't use it, you'll lose it. There's that one teaching. But we mean for you to use it like this. You can use it but use it like this. So we're not encouraged to take money, you know we can get in the car and drive hundreds of miles and sing our hearts out and play and get everybody saved and make revivals and things, and you know maybe they'll take up an offering to make sure you have gas money to get home. But that's not the same thing as paying you for your offering, you know your service through the music. This was a very, very — this still is very much a part of the teaching and has been a conflict for most of my life. And unfortunately to this day I still have to confront that personally in my personal family life and it's a very, very sad truth. So the answer to your question is yes, there are — I have an aunt who is in this film, it's called "Northing But the Blood." And she was my first real piano teacher without being my piano teacher because — physically — because she was the accompanist for the Apostolic Singers when I was about four or five years old and she still does it. And she's in the film. And she's still accompanying. You know she was at church Sunday somewhere playing for someone. Okay? And she's 82 now. And she still has issues with that. She still confronts, at this time in her life with all of that skill, being able to simply receive payment for her work. I've encouraged her in the last maybe twenty years to just allow herself, and give herself permission to just be rewarded however people choose to.

MR: Did your mother, when you decided to go to music school, University of Miami was it?

CL: Yes.

MR: With obviously if you're going to make that commitment you're saying that I'm going to make a career and I'm going to need to get paid. Did she object to that?

CL: No. Not at all. My father did. It was my father, not my mother. It is my mother who's responsible for this beautiful experience I had in life and having seen the world. And without her encouragement and without her creating and finding every possible way to make this happen I wouldn't be talking to you.

MR: Well thanks to your mom.

CL: Thanks, Mom.

MR: Yeah. Was there a particular reason that you switched from opera study to jazz?

CL: Yes. Let's see, I'm going to try and make a synopsis of the whole time. When I entered the University of Miami, having the background that we just talked about — I had a cousin who is an incredible blues guitarist and all this beautiful music happening in my life, I had an aunt who was best friends with the guy that owned the record store so she had everything, you know every new release from everybody and we'd have to go over to her house to hear that stuff because we couldn't listen to it at our own house. So I had already this wonderful exposure to beautiful music prior to becoming serious at that point or from high school. But I was already — I had my first paying job in my junior year of high school with the [s/l] Alshuen Stage Band singing Dionne Warwick and Roberta Flack and blah-blah. When I got to the University of Miami two things happened. I had become friends with a young accompanist in high school, his name was Dave Roitstein who happens to be receiving a Lifetime Achievement at the University of Miami next week, but he's the head of CalArts Music School Jazz Department here in Los Angeles. Now David was the accompanist for the choir in high school. And when I asked him to play for me, because I was always the one playing for, you know, some of my classmates for the talent shows, I asked him to play for me because I really wanted to step out and sing and not have to do this whole piano-sing thing. And when he accompanied me there was something so different about the sound of his piano than my piano. I had come from that Gospel thing, you know second inversions and all that stuff. And David was playing major seventh and ninths and I was like, "What are you doing?" So he was just kind of like just a generous person, you know his nature. He said, "Oh I'm studying Bill Evans right now and I'm playing jazz piano and I'm studying jazz piano. And I'm like, "What is that?" So our friendship just blossomed from that. And by the time I got to the University of Miami I was still in this classical track, I was on this classical track. And David and I had formed a couple of little performances during that summer period before the freshman year. So we were just doing pop tunes, you know like for nursing homes and things like that, and he would bring his Fender Rhodes and set it up and you know we would do our thing. So right in that patch he joined the University of Miami Youth Jazz Band and they needed a vocalist. And that's what happened. So now I'm doing this like Blood, Sweat & Tears and you know that kind of stuff. And now there's the freshman

year of school. And I'm in this classical department and I'm doing all of the arias and I'm learning all this stuff and it was great because I got wonderful vocal instruction that has allowed me to sustain a fifty year career so thank you for that. But David was also at the University of Miami in the jazz department. We did not know that we were both ending up in the same university. We had no idea that this was happening to us. So when I got there, and maybe it was because I had sort of become familiar with some of the people during that summer, during the youth jazz band concerts, maybe other things were kind of working themselves out for me. But I sustained this whole classical thing for the entire time I went to the University of Miami. But in the end it was like the beginning of my sophomore year, I really wanted to do this jazz thing but they didn't have a curriculum for jazz singers. So they allowed me, Jerry Coker, they had a jazz department and the head of the classical department allowed me to go into the study but I had to do both, so I had this double music major. So now I'm staying in the classical but I'm now adding courses that had to do with composition, jazz arranging, improvisation, and they really treated me that way. In other words I just — my instrument was voice you see. So when it came time to improvise it wasn't like they said okay do that on the piano. But now I'm taking jazz piano courses, I'm taking all these jazz courses and I'm staying in the classical department and I did both for the entire time. And I graduated as a jazz major. The curriculum for the jazz vocalist was established about three years after I left. So I kind of initiated this program without really, kind of having an intention to do so. But that's kind of that little space in time where it really was a natural course of events. I think the reason that I was allowed to do this was because a lot of the jazz classmates that many of whom you'd know if I called their names you would know them, they would ask me to do their songs that they had to write for that class assignment or, "Can you sing — I wrote some lyrics for this Carmen, would you mind doing this tune for me?" You know. And the cool thing about it was while I had a little familiarity along the standards, this is an original idea — sing this new song that my classmate wrote. I couldn't run to the library and find a version of it and kind of learn it based on the other vocalist's rendition you see? I actually had to learn it and get inside the tune and perform it. So I was kind of forced to hear my own take on something. I was kind of in that place where it's the other composer's idea that I'm working with on this new song that I'm kind of helping him — he or she to realize what has been written. So that was kind of the osmosis part I think.

MR: Did the classical music voice teachers ever say to you, "I don't like what I'm hearing, where is this coming from? Are you doing jazz? Or were you blessed with open-minded profs?

CL: Yes. Yes, yes, yes, yes, yes. Mary Henderson Buckley was my first voice teacher at the University of Miami and Mary Henderson Buckley flat out, straight up, classical voice. Okay? And I studied with her for my first two and a half years, or something like that. We're talking a while ago. And something interesting occurred. And the cool thing about Mary Henderson Buckley was she knew that I was kind of floating back and forth and there's something called a jury where every Friday at noon classical vocalists, you know, the jazz artists, you had to perform for the faculty. That was the way it was. And these juries were where I kind of got, you know they were allowing me to kind of present the other side of what I was exploring so I would do the aria and then I would do some other kind of pop tune or whatever. But the cool thing was she knew David was upstairs in the jazz department and she'd bring him in for some of my lessons to hear me work with the tune or whatever I was going to do, the non-classical tune. So it just so happened that her experience introduced her to musical theater. So she was very familiar with all of those tunes that jazz artists took from the theater and turned into jazz standards. Sorry that's my ride cymbal. So Mary Henderson Buckley was a super cool person and she was a great teacher, and all we did was seriously work on my technique and there was a portion of my lesson, a 90-minute lesson, wherein maybe the last twenty, thirty minutes was where we'd kind of work on a song, or work on whatever it was, the aria, the jazz standard, whatever. So Mary Henderson Buckley, I think she was very instrumental in talking them into allowing me to switch majors and go into the studio music and jazz major. And then, two and a half years later a gentleman moved from Germany to Miami to become the head of the voice department at the University of Miami. And his name was Dr. Robert Brewster. Dr. Robert Brewster was a black man who was the tenor. You know he was the tenor. And he got this job and apparently he moved back to the United States because his mother had become ill and he wanted to return to the United States and he became the head of the classical department, the voice classical department. And he was my teacher. So he became my teacher. And he was also very, he was an incredible pianist by the way. An incredible pianist as well as an amazing vocalist. So this was a continuation of this. And I was just allowed to pursue every avenue without any real pushback from anyone. I never really — I can't remember ever being told oh no, no you must not, and you can not. That never happened.

MR: That's terrific because the jazz education was not established like it is now, so the fact that you had that positive experience is very nice to hear. I wonder if you ever brought an original song to your lessons at that time?

CL: Oh gosh, oh my God you're asking me — that's okay. I don't remember but I do recall at some point — oh no that was in my New York days because Dr. Brewster moved to New York three years after I moved to New York and I picked up my studies again with him.

And that's when I realized that for an amazing of a pianist, he didn't understand the jazz theory and the jazz jargon so if I handed him a chart and the chart said A minor seven/ D seven/G, he didn't know what to do because it wasn't written out. You know what I mean? So but other than that I just never really — I'm trying to think did I — I don't remember. I'm sorry, I wish I could.

MR: That's okay because we're going to return to that. I'm fascinated by your original, your songwriting. But you said when you went to New York you went there, you wanted to be a bona fide jazz singer. Did you have to pay dues in another way? In other words did you have to get a day job in order to pursue, to pay for your calling?

CL: Hmm. I just realized, this is 2023. I've been doing this consecutively for fifty years plus now. Okay? And I've never done anything but music, anything but music. Even if I were in some acting thing I could sing. You know what I mean? I mean there was a part where you had to sing something, so I was never not singing for a living. That's all I've ever done. I don't know the first thing about waiting tables although I think I'm a pretty good chef myself and I'm happy to invite people over and serve them, but I don't know anything and it's kind of scary because it's a good thing that I have some background with this and I've kind of developed a good — I think I'm a good teacher, I think I work well with young people, but I've never, I have no experience whatsoever out in a day job realm of life.

MR: I'm guessing that accompanists, bass players and piano players and guitar players like to work with you because I doubt you would ever call a tune that you didn't know your own key or have a chart on or an arrangement idea.

CL: Absolutely. So when I moved to New York it was the late 70s, okay? And there was a preparation for that. I was, during my years at the University of Miami I sang six nights a week, three sets 9:00 to 1:00 in any venue that would hire me. Most of the gigs, back then when you booked a gig it lasted for a year, or it lasted for at least, at a minimum a month and then some other artist would come in and then you'd come back in in a month, you know two months later and it was like that sort of thing. So the way I kind of provided for myself during my university years was singing every night in Miami somewhere. My first full time, a full year, my very first employment was at the Eden Roc Hotel in Miami Beach. Prior to that the very first gig it didn't last a year but it lasted a full summer going into that year and that gig was on North Miami Beach at a place called the Pirate's Cove and the group was called Shadow, and I was the shadow. And okay, so that was the summer. So it was like cool, you didn't have to get up and make the 8:30 theory class in the summer. But when I got that gig at the Eden Roc, that gig lasted for a year. And I played at the Eden Rock Hotel and when we booked the gig we had to audition for that gig. David Roitstein, the same guy I mentioned, was the pianist. And when we auditioned

for that gig there was a meeting. The president of the hotel wanted to talk to me without the band, okay? This was kind of scary, you know you do your audition, you do your four or five songs and then the owner of the hotel wants to talk to you. So I go into his office and he was very, very, you know I guess very classy fellow he was, and he just said, "Well we were wondering, Miss Lundy, would you consider changing your name?" Because the room that I would be playing for that full year is called the Mona Lisa Lounge or something like that. It wasn't the main stage where the Smothers Brothers and Jackie Gleason and all those people played, okay? But it was inside this major hotel in Miami Beach. He asked me, "Would you consider changing your name to Mona?" And I thought — and there's no one else there, it's like the band's not there. So I just kind of said to him, "No, sir, I really don't think so." Right? So I leave the meeting thinking oh no, I've lost the gig for everybody. You know? We don't have the gig now because I didn't agree to change my name to Mona, but we ultimately did get the gig and so from that point, so imagine nine to one I've got to drive all the way to Miami Beach every night and drive home every night, and get up for that 8:30 theory class. And I did that for a year, you understand? For years. So when it came time, now school is kind of ending and I'm looking and I go, "What happened to Pat Metheny?" "Oh he left and moved to New York." "Well where is Mark Egan?" "Oh he moved to New York." "Oh well where's Patty Scialfa?" "Oh she moved to New York." And where is da-da-da — oh they moved to New York. "Where's Hiram? Hiram Bullock?" "Oh he moved to New York." I'm thinking what is this New York thing and what is everybody doing going to this New York place? What is it? I mean I'm a sheltered kid. I don't know anything about New York I mean except for the Empire State Building or whatever. I didn't know there was this, this was the hub of the jazz world. I had no idea. When I listened to music I would listen to the music, I wasn't listening to where they were playing or where they were recording you know. And so I made a decision on the very last engagement that I had that was a full year in Coconut Grove at a place called Monty Trainer's Village Inn which is around the corner from the Coconut Grove Playhouse. It's where I was introduced to black Broadway. I decided that I was going to make this move. So that's what I did. So in 1978 I moved to New York and guess what happened? I walked right in to a full time weekend performance for a whole year at a club on 23rd Street in Manhattan called Jazzmania. And Jazzmania there was a time in New York where there were a lot of loft venues. So you'd go to outside of the Village Vanguard, the Village Gate and all the major venues there were these loft venues popping up everywhere. And I played Jazzmania. And I had that gig, I sort of became the house vocalist because there was no term for that back then, but that's where I began to become acquainted, people became familiar with me because I would just hand them the chart and say, you know, "

'Twisted' in D." In D? And the piano player would go, "D?" You know you don't mean F? You don't mean B flat? You know what I mean? "You mean 'Twisted' in D?"

MR: This is not a blues gig.

CL: Exactly. But it is for guitars. So what happened was each weekend this Jazzmania, Mike Morgenstern, who has a venue down in Miami actually, Mike would hire. He was a tenor player, is a tenor player. But he would hire the most, whoever the player was that was available that weekend so from Walter Bishop Junior to Jackie Byard to oh my God to Ronnie Mathews to Kenny Barron, to Don Pullen oh Jesus God, I mean the bassists, the drummers. I mean it was like this major plethora of awesome players and Ronnie Mathews, did I say him already? And any given weekend I would be on the bandstand with these amazing players. So I'd have to walk up and say "Like Someone in Love in A flat." And they'd go, "Hold on a second." You know and how do you want to start. So there's where I got this thing where I said oh I see, so the arrangements would happen right then on the bandstand. I'd go you know let's start at the bridge, because I learned that from them. Sometimes if you're jamming you don't want to just count every tune off and just go you know. So these world class players would have all kinds of tricks in their bag. Arrangements. Ways of getting in and out of the tunes you know. And I was a listener. I'm a really good listener. So I started to incorporate that, those kinds of ways of approaching my arrangements so the next weekend I'd go I don't know who I'm going to be with but let me scribble out a chart on "Street of Dreams." Yeah I like that tune. Let me do that and I'll start with an F sharp 7, no F 7 because that'll be easier for them. And I would do that sort of thing. So that entire year I worked every weekend with these awesome players. So what occurred, Walter Bishop Junior, another, he's one of those great pianists who is associated with Charlie Parker. So Walter Bishop Junior took a shine to my talent, my little girl, you know, and he hired me –- I did a record with him. He hired me for one of my first record dates. Roger Rosenberg hired me for one of my first record dates in New York, and I started getting calls. "I got a gig at so-and-so you want to make it?" And then I got this great gig in Harlem that lasted for a year with — it was an organ trio. And I can tell you it was Roland Prince on guitar and Don Pullen on organ, Bucky Thorpe on flugelhorn and Bobby Battle from Detroit on drums. And I did that for a year. So I'm all over. You know I'm going wherever the gig takes me. And you know New Jersey, Connecticut, I'd jump on the bus or jump on the train and wherever. And that's what I did. And I somehow managed to have enough work and enough opportunity that I never really, there was never any space in time for me to go and find some kind of a day job because there was always this opportunity that somehow sustained me.

MR: Working with all those established piano players must have increased your already developed hearing because Don Pullen is not going to play all the same changes that Walter Bishop Junior is even though the tune may be the same. Did you find that you followed them when they went to different places or did you try to like just stick to what you knew?

CL: This is, you know jazz is such a wonderful experiment where we're exploring possibilities all the time. It's the nature of the music you know. And I'm young and I'm anxious and I'm learning and I want to be liked, I want to be known and recognized for being a musician not just a singer myself you see and that little arranging part, there's something so wonderful and diplomatic and democratic about the experience of this music and to stay open to the possibilities. And you think you might be on this certain track with the Walter Bishop — and Walter by the way, I took piano lessons with him for a while. And if not for Walter Bishop Junior I think a lot of the things that happened in my harmonic construction would not be there in my music. Now Don Pullen on the other hand, I never, I mean I think my first gig with Don might have been at Jazzmania. But when I got that gig in Harlem a few years later there was no piano anywhere to be — it was all organ. So that's a whole different vibe in itself and Don was always on the edge but he was what I call — anybody who's known for their avant garde or playing on the outside, that's the reason that is — Albert Ayler is another example of that, it's because they are so, they come from inside. They come from, you know, the depths of the blues, the intricate, you know, spiritual aspects of Gospel music. So when they go out on the edge and they're experimenting like that, or expressing themselves that way, it's not some random sort of like oh pick a note any note. It's not like that at all. It's really from a centered place, this expression is an evolution of that, that simplistic approach that we start with at the piano. C-E-G triads or what have you. And then you discover the flat seventh oh my God, the flatted seventh is everything, you know the tritone. My God, the tritone. That interval in and of itself you know. And actually Walter Bishop Junior did publish a book, *A Study in Fourths* it's called, by Walter Bishop Junior. And the entire book is nothing but all of these things he derived from just playing perfect fourths. And you know there are famous tunes that I can recall like "Witch Hunt" [scats] you know, that phase, that time where bebop and modern jazz were kind of at this wonderful precipice and sort of like playing off each other. There are a lot of things that I got from Walter Bishop Junior that are very much a part of how I approach harmony to this day. And then there's Don whose melodic sensibilities are ridiculous. And they had their own trios and if you heard, if you ever heard Don Pullen, with Adams and Danny Richmond — you know what can I say. So my, you know we're talking, now check this out, everything we're talking about has nothing to do with the singers. I'm not even talking

about singers yet, okay? We haven't even talked about the Ellas and the Sarahs and the Carmen McRaes and the Bettys and all that. Okay? This is just how the music — I think I was a sponge, I think I still am. I was just absorbing from the masterful, from the masters really, of that time. I'm in my early twenties and they are fully realized artists at that time in their careers. And I'm just really taking whatever they offer and happy to be in the mix.

MR: Do you think there's a difference — well there's a difference sometimes between instrumentalists and vocalists — but I frequently ask the question of practicing jazz musicians now if there are wrong notes in improvising. And almost all of them say no, like emphatically. And then they may go on and explain, well let me tell you why. But so my question is if Miles Davis played a note that sort of perks up your ear and you go like why did he choose that but he gets away with it, does a singer have the same liberty to get away with it?

CL: Wow that's a great question.

MR: You know you're putting a word to it, and the word goes with a note that people may expect but you're choosing a different note supposedly on purpose.

CL: Huh. Well that's a great question. I've never been asked that question. I'm just reminded of someone walking up to Miles Davis and saying, "Man that was amazing on that record you did with" da-da-da-da. And how did you — where did you come up with [scats]." And he will say, "It was a mistake." The person is like — but and then Betty Carter would always say, "When you make a mistake it's how you recover." Okay? That's it. That's the answer. It's how — okay and that's Betty's answer and she is a great singer, all right, our great Betty Carter. And she would say it's all about how you recover. Okay? So sometimes it's the mistake that leads you into the most amazing adventure with everyone, if everybody's listening and not judging you for like oops-a-daisy. I think there are certain things that do occur and they sometimes happen from the bottom up. So say I've got this chart, I've written it out and we're playing the tune, and the bass player hits the wrong note. The bass hits the wrong note. Oops-a-daisy. Okay? Now that, and that has to do, that bass player better know that it's about how to recover too, you see what I mean? Because you can take those kind of mistakes and they can become this channel. Like you know when you watch water kind of traveling where there's a flood and you're like, "Where's it going to go, where's it going to go?" You know. And suddenly you're down this path that you never saw yourself going. You know what I mean? So I think that that's being open and having really big ears but as a vocalist I think that the word, I think it's weird to make a mistake with a lyric than it is to make a mistake with a note. I do. I think the wrong lyric, if it comes at the wrong time, is like how do you recover from that?

MR: Yeah that makes people put their drink down and go, "Wait a minute" —

CL: "Wait a second. It doesn't go like that." And I love the way, if you think about it, Ella Fitzgerald on that famous "How High the Moon" she goes [sings] "I guess if you were wondering what I'm singing." You know what I mean?

MR: Yeah she got through the whole "Mac the Knife" without I think singing any of the original lyric except maybe the title. That takes some nerve.

CL: Oh yeah, and skill.

MR: I have to fast forward because if I don't get some input on you on these songs I won't sleep tonight. I wanted to ask you a couple of specific things about recent compositions and from "Modern Ancestors" you wrote a song called "Flowers and Candles."

CL: Yes.

MR: There's a line about one minute in, at least the video I watched where you sing a downward melodic phrase and the words are "in a place where innocence has died." And if my ears are correct when you hit the end of that line you landed on the root of the key you're in, but the chord did not. The chord was not what the ear was expecting. It might have been down a whole step or it might have been just a thicker chord. And can you recall when you sat and wrote that how did that happen?

CL: You mean with the chord not landing on the tonic?

MR: Yeah, the note landed on the tonic but the chord didn't go there, it was different and then a few bars later it sort of got where the ear was expecting. I don't mean to make too much out of this but it certainly perked me up, it made me like do my head like that.

CL: Well if you consider the lyric "had died" okay? So if I said, "In a place where innocence had died." So it's like going [sings] "In a place where innocence has died." So I think that we're in — there's something about that emotion or that truth about the morbidity of a thought of innocence dying. What am I saying there? So perhaps that was the interpretation of my accompaniment to suggest something sonically that had to do with that. Do you understand? It's a sonic interpretation. So to just have a perfectly beautiful major chord would not necessarily incline that emotion. You see what I mean? You understand what I mean? And I don't recall anything unusual or kind of jarring about it. I'd have to go back and listen, because I haven't listened to that tune in a while. But I think the accompaniment, I think the gift and the role of the accompaniment is to really support not only the lyric and whatever the music is but the emotional aspects of it too. And I kind of like, you know, Phrygian modal sounds in harmony. They don't throw my ear. I kind of like that — I'm going to use a kind of a —

MR: I think we may have lost you

CL: Are you there?

MR: I am here now.

CL: Okay I have no idea what that was.

MR: Yeah I lost you — we'll — in the words of old fashioned, we'll splice that out.

CL: Okay so it's funny that we're talking about this. And so yeah, I think that whatever that is you're hearing, I'm trying to hear, because my brother is playing, Curtis is on bass on that tune and he's playing the fifth. He's sort of like on the pedal tone [sings] "And the little boy asks his papa." So I'm sort of on a major and minor thing anyway so I'll have to listen again because I'm not really sure exactly —

MR: Yes, and I wouldn't call it jarring, I would call it, once I heard it the second time I said that's highly appropriate, what you did there. And so, the other thing, I'd also like to ask you about "Ain't I Human."

CL: Okay.

MR: Yeah, can you recall if the phrase or the upward four note melodic line came first?

CL: I believe that the melodic — I tend to write the music first. I might have an idea of what's coming lyrically but I generally write tunes and then, because I find the lyric to be the most challenging aspect of songwriting or composition, that the lyric has to be undoubtedly the hardest part. I know that Joni Mitchell for example writes the other way, she writes her lyrics and then sets the music to that. That tune, I've always loved the cello. I'm a mezzo, the cello is in the range of my voice. I've always loved the cello. And at some point I had to have one. I must own the cello. So I went out to the closest music store to where I live and I bought a cello. And in just kind of learning about how to tune it, all these things, right, I realized that the cello tunes in perfect fifths, not fourths like a bass, okay? [scats] Right? I'm loving that. And I've always wanted to incorporate those intervals in something, in a tune. So I knew that I was going there, that's what I was kind of — working and composition to me is like an eight hour gig. You get up and you start and you go and you just kind of hope that you arrive at something before the end of the day. So this was like, I was kind of like, okay let's really get inside this whole thing. And as I'm sitting at the piano with the fifths and realizing you know we have the cycle of fifths, we have all these things we study in theory. So now I'm going oh my God, this is so, the space, almost the overtone series itself you could almost kind of hear where this thing is infinite if it's really tuned perfectly. And then all these awful things were happening in the world at the same time. "Ain't I Human" the idea is born from a Sojourner Truth's famous speech during the women's suffrage movement and the women's right to vote and she walks in and says, "Ain't I human? I gave birth to your babies" and whatever, and "Ain't I human?" You know? And "Ain't I a woman?" And "Ain't I a woman?" And "Ain't I a woman" as a black woman during huh, I mean one of the most horrible periods of American history she's standing there — I think about it sometimes, it's just like, it moves me to think about it. So we had a lot of awful things happening during the phase of this writing of Fade to Black and that was one of them. So

I got this idea, the perfect fifths going on, and I'm thinking how can I convey to the listener this vulnerable place that we all live in as human beings, wanting and aspiring to the same things. Love, fulfillment, vocation, employment, stability, homeownership, whatever the heck. We all aspire to these things as humans. So I was like how can I take this idea I had — that's when I started singing [sings arpeggio] in perfect fourths, the interval the fourth. So now I've got this fifth thing going on with the piano, and I'm singing fourths. But it's intentional to stay away from anything that's do-re-mi-fa-sol — it was not about that. And that's kind of that thing where you have to work at every aspect of this developed art form and some of it has to do with technique and some of it has nothing to do with technique. Okay? And this is one where it was very difficult technically to sing that over and over again. It's not easy. Because our culture, we're trained to hear things in mi-re-do — do-re-mi-fa-sol — everything is that scale. So I was doing my best to stay away from that in "Ain't I Human." So these are the things that all come together in this composition to tell the story. And I've got the bass, not a cello — because I couldn't get a cello for this record date for that simple thing I was hearing. Matthew Whittaker did a beautiful job on strings programming but I had this [scats] so there's two bass players on that track. There's my brother Curtis playing arco because I wanted this orchestration, I wanted like three contrabasses. That's what I wanted. So I had Curtis, I had my brother just holding down, just holding those bottom notes, and Kenny Davis on the other bass, I had two bassists here in the studio, and Kenny's on the other upright bass [scats]. So this was my way of doing a kind of a condensed orchestration to fit this vulnerable statement that I wanted to make about observation and American society in the 21st Century that's not making a lot of sense to me. And that's what comes out.

MR: Are most of your —these specific songs, I was going to ask about "Eye of the Storm" also. I'm wondering if you mostly record with everybody at the same time?

CL: Wow? You've been doing a lot — thank you for these great questions.

MR: Well you know I've done a little studio work over the years and when I was watching "Eye of the Storm" and some of your songs have rubato sections, extended sections and then you hit something new, something changes. And I was envisioning the musicians trying to play if you weren't there. And that would be very difficult it seems.

CL: Well so I have always recorded — I record everything I do. Okay? I record every idea I have. And I have for decades. And I just kind of change with the formatting. So if it was a four-track cassette back in the day or whatever it was, a four-track reel to reel, and then it became an A-dat, then it became this, that and the other. So I've always recorded. And in the last I would say the last eight or nine projects of mine I pre-record every idea I have. So I started out using what they call plug-ins or those samples that are part of the

software and fake, you know like they're loops of instruments but they repeat and repeat and repeat. And they kind of support your idea but they don't really play your song. So I got away from that. I got away from borrowing, you know bossa nova 101 and all that stuff, and began to play the drums myself and play the bass and play the piano, play the guitar. So I would record that. I would record my drums. Record the bass. Sometimes it would be keyboard bass, sometimes I would actually pick up one of the basses. And sometimes picking up one of the basses informed me, more so than just the keyboard bass. So if I would do this, oh I see, oh I get it, that fingering that's going to be [inaudible] — so things like that occur and I go back and then I can advance whatever these concepts are that I have in mind. I record everything and I became very fortunate to have met a wonderful recording engineer who embraced my pre-records and embraced what someone might call demos, but they were actually full albums. I would do everything before I would hire the musicians to come in and play. So my musicians, when they come into the studio and we record everything, they've already heard my full album where I've played everything, which gives them permission and the freedom to now insert their own feeling and ideas because they have an idea already of what I can see. You see? And that's why we're rendering these kinds of recordings and these kinds of performances because the musicians are, "Oh Carmen, oh she's already covered, she's made this easy for me. I see what she wants there. Oh okay, great." So that gives them, they can take what I've written and because they're the skilled player on that instrument, I'm not, but they actually stay true, and of course I write everything down note for note. So if the tune needs it I'm going to write out that bass line. Or I'm going to write something on the chart that's – simile or something. Here's what I want and then you just be yourself. But these are all the different tools that are now part of my particular approach to getting the music to the stage. Getting the music to the listener. So what we do is we take my pre-records, everybody knows, because I've already sent them the printed music, they've got my full album and they just kind of go, "Oh you want me to go — oh yeah" and now all these other things occur that I could never have imagined. And that's what's beautiful about this process. And that's what I think — I don't know if my music really translates that way to my listeners and you kind of have to be in the room when you're seeing me play it live, but there's already so much work that has gone into what you hear ultimately and what my engineer — my engineer is so wonderful, he'll say, "Well Carmen, you know that's really a nice thing you did there," you know where I might have had some kind of a plug-in of maybe a brass section or something. And I'll bring in a tenor player, and I'll bring in a trumpet player and maybe a trombone for the session, but when we get to the mix he'll say, "Let's pull up what you did and let's see if we can take your plug-ins and somehow I'll mix it with, you know, with Wallace Roney

Junior or with Gifton Garrett — I mean Giveton Gelin — and let's see what that sounds like just to have them both. Let's not just mute all that work you've done. You've done all this work why should we just mute it?" So that's so wonderful to work with an engineer who also is a musician. Do you understand? It's not just about dials and things, this guy's a musician too. So I've evolved over the course of all these decades as a writer, as a singer. And some of it is a little bit of a, I'm a little bit in a quandary because I don't understand why the audience wants me to come to the stage and give them "Street of Dreams" when I've got up "Flowers and Candles." Okay, on "Eye of the Storm" is the perfect example okay? "Eye of the Storm." My family is from Miami. I'm from Miami. And they were getting ready to see another horrific hurricane come through. And my family just happened to be one of those places on the planet that was devastated when Andrew came in back in the 90s. Okay? My family was nearly wiped out. And all the things that occurred subsequent to that, you know health issues and all kinds of other things that occurred with my family down there in Miami. So here it is like twenty years later or thirty, or whatever it is and there's another storm pending and I'm in L.A. going oh. And I can hear that recall that they're re-living, that nightmare. So "Eye of the Storm" was born out of that and also what was happening to the country politically. So there were two things going on at that time for the tune. So, but I knew that my concept of this record had to do with modern ancestors, okay, not the Sojourner Truths but the John Coltranes and the Miles Davises and the Nina Simones, okay, and the Carmen McRaes and so forth and so on. And everybody else knew that. And I'm from Miami and I have a huge love and appreciation for every contribution that Dizzy Gillespie and Chano Pozo created for Latin jazz you know, okay? So all these things I want. I'm sort of paying homage to — because these were my lessons, this is of my time. These are the ancestors, these are the ones that gave me the inspiration to do this. So that's what "Modern Ancestors" is all about, is really kind of saying well I'm not one of them but because of them I'm me. You see? That's a big thing. And I'm not sure if the jazz audience has really evolved along with me that way because the jazz vocal genre in and of itself has so much to do with music of a time that has to do with 30s, 40s, 50s, maybe some of the early 60s, maybe some of Bacharach stuff that happened in the 60s perhaps. So no one really is thinking what about jazz in 2022? Jazz vocal in 2022? Oh I see, that's going to be [scats] okay fine. You want me to do that? Okay. But what about this? What about the little kid that's hearing jazz for the first time that's going to say, "I remember when I heard that lady, when my mommy took me to that concert." "How old are you?" "I'm four." It's like what are they going to remember? I don't want them to remember "Summertime." I want them to remember "Flowers and Candles."

MR: Somehow Scott Yanow in this book, he quoted you at the end of your entry here. And apparently you said, "I asked the jazz community, the listeners, critics and record companies to continue to support, embrace and reward originality."

CL: Original?

MR: Originality.

CL: Oh originality. Oh I'm glad you read that. There was a film that I happened to stumble into, Liza Manelli — it might have been "Arthur" but I'm not sure if it was "Arthur." But the very last scene she's in a fur coat, she's the star, and there's like it's the end of the film and everyone is like "Liza, Liza, Liza." And she gets into the limo and a little girl stops her before she gets into the car. And the little girl says, "Liza" and she turns around and of course there's this cute little girl. And the cute little girl comes up and goes, "I want to be just like you." And Liza says, "Don't be like me, sweetheart, because America loves an original." And she gets in the car and that's the end of the movie. Okay? And I was like oh, boy did I — I'm so glad I tuned into the last five minutes of that film. But I think about that. Originality has always been part of the evolution. I was thinking the other day you know Miles gave us "My Funny Valentine" but he also gave us "Four." He also gave us "Sketches of Spain." He also gave us "In a Silent Way." Okay? And John Coltrane gave us "My Favorite Things" but he also gave us "A Love Supreme." You understand? So why can't a jazz vocalist give you "Them There Eyes" and then "God Bless the Child" you see? So I really feel like that's where I am with the journey as much of my history is very much rooted in this vocabulary. I think I should be allowed to evolve as well.

MR: As do I. And I have great respect — you know I've often felt that every major city in the United States has any number of singers who are blessed with a great voice. But for me the fact that you write your own music, you do your charts, you put all this effort into it, good for you. It's the best. I'm not sure how to express my admiration for it, but I'm trying. And I appreciate your time today. I guess I'll wrap up, we've been at it for a while, but I wonder in the "Eye of the Storm" you're saying beware the calm before the storm and it's like a warning. So I'm going to ask you if you think of yourself as an optimist.

CL: You broke up. A warning?

MR: Do you think of — your "Eye of the Storm" seemed to be a warning in its lyrics. Beware the calm before the storm — and sometimes I wonder if we are in the storm. So do you think you're an optimist?

CL: I think — I have a very positive — I think the music has informed me. And creativity is a positive thing. This wonderful part of the human experience, tapping into our creativity — sometimes I wonder, without really knowing it, the artist has a wonderful perspective I

think because we come to center stage and then we play to the listener. Sometimes it only takes one person playing and suddenly the magic begins because somebody's listening. And I wonder sometimes, because so much of my life experience has been at center stage around the world several times, that I come away with an understanding, this commonality of — cultures may be different but there's a human condition that's unique to all of us as people. And I wonder sometimes if I'm informed or if I can see or observe in such a way that allows me this sense of being able to express in a global sense what we all really yearn for in our own life. And some people call that clairvoyance you know, some people say you were born with a veil, you can kind of look into the future. I don't feel that way about it. I don't. I try to be, and jazz improvisation asks this of you, to be in the moment. You can't play the solo you did last week and expect for the same thing to happen on the bandstand, even though you blew everyone away and you wonder where all those ideas came from yourself, right? And you've got to get out there and go I'm going to do this again, and it doesn't happen, right? So there is something about being true to the moment and music demands that of you. I'll never forget that night at Mikell's in New York when I was introducing something from my first album, "Good Morning Kiss." I'm about to sing "The Lamp is Low" a beautiful song by Parish and DeRose based on who is it, the classical composer — oh Gosh I can't think of it right now. Anyway and he said, so I'm announcing this song and he goes, "And it better be just like the record" the guy yells. I'm introducing this song in a live setting and the guy goes, "It better be —" So I think that what I am experiencing is a wonderful gift in and of itself. I'm very happy to be encouraged by my mother and that somehow along the way the universe gave me what I needed you know, to continue. And beware the calm — I heard that guy that was impeached twice, I heard him say that once. I heard him actually say that. So I'm thinking whoa — and that was early on. And I'm thinking well maybe the storm was January 6. Maybe this is the storm now. But whatever I heard back then that came out of this concern for my family, you know that was personal. But I'm hearing the world like everybody else you know. We have mortgages and bills to pay like everybody else. So I'm also a part of this everyday stuff, occurrences, that we try our best to absorb and take from it what we will and move on. But I think it's important for the artist to say I'm aware of this too. And I'm not going to sing you another love song. That's the next track, okay? Or that's the last record or maybe the next record I'll do will be nothing but love songs. But right now — and there's really a love in this song but it's kind of — it's more than that. So I think that's what's going on for me is that I'm looking for ways to really remind us of what 2021 was like when it's 2035 you see. And maybe that's sort of, without knowing is maybe one of my intentions.

MR: Wonderful. And I did hear "A Love Supreme" as that tune faded out.

CL: I don't know where that came from.

MR: I was going to ask where did that come from.

CL: I don't know where that came from. We were just in the tune you know, and all that had happened, you know the track, right, so it's like seven minutes or nine minutes already and then out of — and then when I did it I said, "Oh we'll be out by then." We listened to the playback and I said, "Oh we'll be faded by then" you know the tune won't last that long, we won't do that. And there it was, we kept it, because it was all part of that thing. And I think that was the most beautiful part of it all, that the modern ancestors and the whole idea of what I was doing, somehow this John Coltrane entered the recording session, you know whoa. But that's the beautiful, spiritual part of what we do.

MR: Thank you. I've really enjoyed this conversation. And I appreciate it and I hope that — I know you'll keep doing what you've been doing.

CL: Oh thank you so much, Monk, and I've got to tell you that it turns out that my sister-in-law went to Hamilton years ago, and my brother-in-law actually. So they both studied there. And I like those kind of coincidences. And I will be headed to Harvard at the end of next month to do a residency there, so I'm looking forward to that.

MR: Awesome. Well your — I was going to say that your experience, your fifty years of experience should yield all kinds of excellent information for today's students.

CL: Well let's look forward to that. I certainly hope so.

MR: All right. Well I'll pause and we'll say our good-byes.

CL: Okay. Okay.